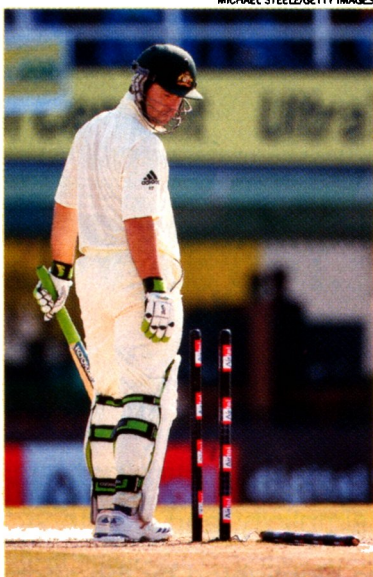


AFTERSHOCKS

DROWNED UNDER

Bring back Symonds. Bring back Warne. Whatever you do, bring back the Golden Age. Australia have been left pole-axed by the capitulation of their team in Mohali. What surprised witnesses more than Australia's defeat was its manner. Its batsmen may have been befuddled by Zaheer Khan and Ishant Sharma's conventional and reverse swing and Amit Mishra and Harbhajan Singh's control and turn. Its bowlers may have run into shotmakers and veterans who picked them apart. But what proved most damning was the Aussies fielding in Mohali, minus characteristic energy or signature accuracy. If fielding is a reflection of a team's state of mind and its cohesion, then what can you make of the Australian close cordon not producing a single direct hit in Mohali?

The result has produced the most surprising reactions out of the country that had established the rules and called the shots in world cricket for well over a decade. A reader called Nick left this comment on a website of the Sydney-based *Daily Telegraph*: "A message to Ricky Ponting... start supporting your players, you coconut." It was not the fury in the reader's tone but the fact that an



MICHAEL STEELE/GETTY IMAGES

THE AUSSIE FIELDING IN MOHALI WAS MINUS THEIR CHARACTERISTIC ENERGY OR SIGNATURE ACCURACY.

Australian captain was being instructed to stand by his men. Watching Ponting and Brett Lee gesticulate at each other during the Indian second innings was proof that pressure tells on all cricketers in the same way: even those who believe they have the monopoly on preaching the gospel of the game to the world.

Given the line-up of the teams, Mohali should have been an inevitability. Since 2001, India is the only country to consistently challenge Australia. Of the four series held in that time, Australia has won two and drawn one but the 17 Tests are now split at six wins apiece. For this series to come alive, the pre-eminent rivalry in modern cricket needs to be joined. Australia must do an India, must do what was done to them in 2001: return from the dead.



GLOBAL CRICKET VENTURES/BCCI VIA GETTY IMAGES

SHINING THROUGH: Record-breaker Tendulkar with 7,000-Test run man Ganguly

it's just too bad. Drop a batsman, say those wanting bravado. Drop Laxman, some say, sensing impending doom. A few even say drop Ganguly, out of what must be habit or deteriorating cognition.

"The best XI must play," says former chairman of selectors Kiran More, and his relief at not having to be the arbiter of that is evident. "Anil is not the one to cheat the team because of injuries, either way." Chappell believes Mishra is important because he "poses difficult questions for this line-up... he tests their footwork in a different way." Reverting to Kumble would be "sending India backwards". Former India keeper Saba Karim insists, "You have to keep your balance, get back to Kumble... It's important not to get carried away by one fine performance."

Kumble's drive to be fit for Delhi will shift the focus from his senior batsmen who were being called deadwood before the series began. The Bangalorean had torn into the media in his newspaper column, censuring them for not being more 'supportive'. When he returns to the field in Delhi, he must know that the only guarantee is scrutiny, not support.

The series had begun with shrill calls for new blood because the memory of Test defeat in Sri Lanka was fresh, the appeal of the shorter game and its youthful protagonists was irresistible, and India's most experienced batsmen hover around 35. Against Australia, the batters weighed in, set new records and formidable benchmarks. But their tomorrows, not their yesterdays, remain of interest and so every struggle will be interpreted as failure, every stumble, a portent of the fall. In Delhi, Kumble will be at the centre of the debate again. In another city, in the near future, it will be someone else.

Javagal Srinath, colleague to all five, says there is a way out. "The best way is for the players to set a time frame themselves and to announce it. It will help to plan the transition." They may have all worked to annihilate Australia in Mohali, but India's finest ever clutch of Test players knows that their great siege continues. ■